

The efficacy of an anti-virus solution is estimated by testing against viruses in the wild and those historically called *zoo* viruses. In-the-wild ones are responsible for wreaking havoc as we read in the newspapers, while the *zoo* viruses are either outdated or are captive in the databases of virus researchers. The open source model allows for faster response time to new outbreaks. Yes, even faster than your favourite commercial anti-virus solution. But most of the open source anti-virus tools fail to detect as many *zoo* viruses and often generate false positives unlike their proprietary counterparts. This could be attributed to the fact that they arrived at a later date and missed out the early threats posed by those *zoo* viruses.

On the other hand, many people can look into the detection engines, fix bugs and provide quicker solutions. Caveat emptor! In July 2004, a test was conducted by University of Hamburg's Virus Test Center. You may have already guessed: ClamAV, celebrating its first birthday at the time, fared pathetically in the tests. It detected fewer than 50 per cent of in-the-wild and *zoo* viruses compared to the 90 per cent accuracy of commercial rivals. Though it's been a long time since such a test has been conducted, the general belief is that false positive rates and misses are more frequent in ClamAV. Coming to the point, the open source virus database has signatures of over 71,000 viruses till date, which could just be a third of the actual number. Still, it is not that bad a number, noting that many viruses that are not detected comprise *zoo* ones, which cease to cause any harm today. Moreover, as soon as a newer strain is released, the ClamAV community is one of the first few to respond.

8.1.3 The Clam package for Windows

MS Windows has long been a favourite target of viruses. While cross-platform viruses may just be lurking around, a huge percent of viruses is confined to that OS. Luckily, the Clam pack has a release for Windows, called ClamWin. ClamWin can be obtained from www.clamwin.com/content/view/18/46/